



Emerging champion: R. Vaishali became India's 84th Grandmaster in 2023. She's only the third Indian woman to achieve the title.

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three mandatory GM norms from the 2019 Xtracon Open, the 2022 Fischer Memorial, and the 2023 Qatar Masters, she took her rating past the stipulated 2500 marks in the 2023 El Llobregat Open in December.

The last month of the year also saw Vaishali winning the prestigious Arjuna Award and her coach, noted trainer R. B. Ramesh, getting the Dronacharya Award. These awards were presented in January of 2024.

The year's last week brought India a silver medal in the World Rapid tournament, with former champion Humpy making a brilliant comeback and coming up with a strong finish.

With the addition of six more Grandmasters — M. Pranesh, N. R. Vignesh, Sayantan Das, V. Praneeth, Aditya Samant, and Vaishali — India's tally rose to 84.

Elsewhere, five-year-old Tejas Tiwari became the youngest-rated player in the world with a tally of 1149. This was just the kind of news that underlined India's claim to be the next superpower in the sport.

The cash-rich Global Chess League made its debut in Dubai, where some of the leading names, headed by Carlsen, showed up. Much like what the Indian Premier League (IPL) did for lesser-known Indian players, this league should bring a lot of confidence to those who get to be on the same team as some elite players.

Overall, there were plenty of gains right through the year that buried the disappointment of India returning with just two Asian Games silver medals from the team events. Looking forward, 2024 holds the promise of some memorable performances in the Candidates and beyond.

DESPITE JUST TWO ASIAN GAMES SILVER MEDALS IN TEAM EVENTS, THERE WERE NUMEROUS GAINS THROUGHOUT 2023



Purple patch: Vidit Gujrathi had a dazzling run in 2023, during which he won the FIDE Grand Swiss tournament and also qualified for the 2024 Candidates event.